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***al-Muwashshahât* and *al-Qudûd al-Halabiyya*:
Two Genres in the Aleppine *Wasla***

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Overview

This article analyzes two important genres of Arab music that are heard in Syria in the course of the performance of the *wasla*, or suite of songs: the *muwashshahât* and the popular songs known as *al-qudûd al-halabiyya*. Many consider the *muwashshahât* (sing. *muwashshah*) to be the epitome of Arab music. Poetically, melodically, and vocally, the *muwashshahât* constitute a veritable treasure-house of Arabic culture and civilization.¹ The *qudûd* (sing. *qadd*) are sung in both standard and colloquial Arabic, but because of their simpler melodic rhythmic structure are generally considered to be simplified versions of *muwashshahât*; therefore in this article I treat them as a sub-set of the *muwashshahât*.

In contemporary Syria, as elsewhere in the Arab world, the *muwashshahât*, despite their prestige, are increasingly being drowned out by popular song forms and are less often heard than twenty or thirty years ago. Today, younger Syrians are by far more knowledgeable about such pop stars as 'Amru Diyâb and Hakîm, for example, than about 'Umar al-Batsh and Sayyid Darwîsh and other great composers from the early twentieth century. Aside from certain music festivals, such as Egypt's annual Festival of Arab Music (*Mihrajân al-mûsîqâ al-'arabiyya*), Tunisia's Carthage Festival (*Mihrajân qartâ*), among others, and in concerts and private performances in Syria and Morocco, the *muwashshahât* no longer form a part of a living musical tradition in most Arab countries and are rarely heard at such occasions as weddings, parties, and at night clubs. However, in music conservatories around the Arab World the *muwashshahât* remain useful as pedagogical tools for learning and teaching the intricate arts of composition and improvisation in Arab music. For generations of students, learning the *muwashshahât* and the various Arabic instrumental genres, such as the *samâ'i*, *bashraf* and *lûngâ*, has been an important way of mastering the complex systems of *maqâmât* (modes) and *îqâ'ât* (rhythmic cycles) characteristic of Arab music (see

¹ A leading reference on the *muwashshahât* in Aleppo is Fu'âd Rajâ'î and Nadîm al-Darwîsh 1995. *Min Kunûzinâ* [From Our Treasures]. Aleppo, comprising *waslât* of *muwashshahât* in 23 different *maqâmât* (modes).

Currey 2002). The *muwashshahât* are also an indispensable repertory for those training in the vocal arts with their rich mixture of classical Arabic lyrics and intricate modulations.²

Despite the decline of the *muwashshahât* with the rise in popularity of other genres, in more tradition-steeped Syria, and especially in the city of Aleppo, the *muwashshahât* remain alive and well. Singers of all stripes perform them at concerts, night clubs, and weddings, and young and old pack the clubs (*nawâdî*, sing. *nâdî*) of Aleppo to hear Sabâh Fakhri and other artists sing *waslât* or suites of *muwashshahât* and *al-qudûd al-halabiyya*. Religious *muwashshahât* are performed at religious occasions such as the *dhikr* (the ritual remembrance of God) and the *mawlid al-nabi* (celebration of the Prophet Muhammad's birth). At evening gatherings known as *sahrât* (sing. *sahra*), friends gather to listen to older *muwashshahât* and newer ones composed by living musicians. Even for those who do not perform or listen to *muwashshahât*, they nonetheless remain important symbols of the authenticity and the wealth of the Arab musical and literary heritage. In Syria they form an important element of Syrian musical and national identity and figure prominently in discourses of cultural authenticity, heritage preservation, and attempts to define Syrian "tradition" (see Shannon 2001).

The *Wasla* in Aleppo

The *muwashshahât* and *qudûd* must be understood in their primary performance context, which is the *wasla*. The *wasla* is a vocal and instrumental suite of songs that are usually but not always sung in the same *maqâm*. In Aleppo the *wasla* typically consists of the following sequence of genres³:

1. an instrumental introduction such as a *samâ'î* or *bashraf*.
2. a suite of *muwashshahât*: from 3 to 5 or more, all in the same *maqâm*.
3. instrumental improvisations known as *taqâsîm* (sing. *taqsîm*).

² Yet, the melodic aspects of the *muwashshahât* seem to be more important today; for example, the Conservatory in Beirut has published a detailed collection of *muwashshahât* that does not include any lyrics, as if they were meant to be read and studied but not sung (Gholmieh, et al. 1996).

³ A *wasla* performance usually began with the tuning the *qânûn* in the days before the 'urab or tuning levers were common, i.e., before the early 20th century. (Muhammad Qadrî Dalâl, personal communication 1997).

4. *layâlî* (repetition of the phrases *yâ 'ayn*, *yâ layl* to an improvised melody) and *qasîda* (classical poem sung to an improvised melody).
5. *dawr* (a complex, multi-part genre of Egyptian provenance).
6. *mawwâl sharqâwî* or *shargâwî* (also known as *sab'âwî*, based on a seven-line poem) or *mawwâl masrî* (or *khumâsî*, based on a five line poem), followed by *taqâsîm*.
7. *qudûd* and light songs, often in a different *maqâm* from the *muwashshahât*, preceded by a *dûlâb* (a short instrumental prelude) if this is the case.

Structure of the *Wasla*

The overall structure of the *wasla* marks a progression from the slow and heavy rhythms of the initial *muwashshahât* to the quick and light tempos of the *qudûd* and popular songs, passing through stages of suspended time in the *taqâsîm* and improvised vocal genres (see Shannon 2003a). The whole *wasla* may last several hours: for example, a Sabâh Fakhri concert that I attended in Aleppo in 1997 began at 10:00 p.m. and ended at approximately 4:30 a.m., and consisted of two *waslât* interspersed with a short break.

In many ways the *wasla* structure and dynamic is very similar to that of the *dhikr*, that is, both begin with songs set to slow and complex tempos, and modulate by the end to songs set to simpler and faster tempos. There are compelling reasons to suggest that the *wasla* and *dhikr* have shared origins, or that the secular *wasla* in fact derives from religious suites similar to the *dhikr* and the Ottoman cyclical genre known as the *fasil* (al-'Aqîlî 1979; Feldman 1996; Racy 1983).

The *Muwashshah*: A Poetic-Musical Genre

The *muwashshah* is best known in the West as a literary genre, and numerous studies of the *muwashshahât* as poetry and their relationship to European literature have been written in recent years (Liu and Monroe 1989). Yet the *muwashshah* was always at heart a poetic and musical genre: that is, it was written to be sung, and not read as poetry. Of course, in Arabic culture there has always been a strong relationship between poetry and music. As the great Arab poet Adonis has written, "Arabic poetry was born as song" (1992:13) and anyone who has attended a reading by a famous Arab poet such as Mahmoud Darwish, Samîh al-Qâsim, Adonis, and others will recognize that often there is little difference between reading a poem and chanting it.

The term *muwashshah* (pl. *muwashshahât*) derives from the Arabic *wishâh* or *wushâh*, a type of embellished sash or scarf worn across the shoulders by women in medieval times. The word *muwashshah* means, in this regard, "embellished" or "decorated." Some scholars compare the *muwashshah* to the earlier Arabian *musammât*, considered a possible precursor of the *muwashshah* and which literally means "strung like a string of pearls" (see al-Faruqi 1975: 4-5). Therefore the *muwashshah* can be understood as a poetic and musical form of embellishment or decoration. The religious variety of *muwashshah* is sometimes called the *tawshîh* (pl. *tawâshîh*) and a composer of *muwashshahât* is called a *washshâh* (pl. *washâhûn*).

The Origins of the *Muwashshahât*

Most scholarly and popular treatments of the *muwashshah* consider it to be of Andalusian origin, that is, from Muslim Spain (*al-Andalus*), where the Arabs lived and flourished from 711 until 1492 C.E. (see Menocal 2002). Because al-Andalus is most commonly cited as the origin, they are usually called *al-muwashshahât al-andalusiyya*, or Andalusian *muwashshahât*. A number of individuals are thought to have invented the *muwashshah* genre. Some sources argue that the poet Muqaddam Ibn Mu'âfa al-Qabarî first composed *muwashshah* in the ninth century, although there is some debate concerning the first author of *muwashshahât* and few early works survives (see, among others, al-'Aqîlî 1979, al-Faruqi 1975: 4). Very few of the earliest *muwashshahât* survived the passage of time because they were considered by Andalusian poets to be a low – even vulgar – art because they incorporated colloquial verses, especially in the *kharja* or final verse. Therefore good poets did not include *muwashshahât* in their collections (*diwan*-s) since they were not considered appropriate for inclusion alongside the prestigious *qasîda*. Moreover, the absence of consistent musical notation in al-Andalus combined with the dubious literary reputation of the *muwashshahât* at the time makes it difficult to tell who first composed in this genre and what precisely they would have sounded like.

Eastern Arabian or Levantine musical and poetic influences are suggested by the similarities between the *muwashshah* and Eastern Arabian song forms such as the *musammât*, Arabic and Persian quatrains (*rubâ'iyât*) and quintains (*mukhammisât*), and song forms made popular in Iraq during the 'Abbasid era and transmitted to al-Andalus via the famous musician Ziryâb and others (see al-Faruqi 1975: 4-5). It should be noted that the pre-modern Mediterranean basin constituted an open and

fluid cultural system (Abu-Lughod 1989), and scholars traveled from the *mashriq* (the Levant) to the *maghrib* (North Africa), despite the distance and troubles involved. Because of the fluidity of the Mediterranean region it should come as no surprise that musical and poetic forms also traveled from one end to the other.

Some Syrian scholars argue that the ancient song forms of Mesopotamia and Byzantium, collected and notated by the Syriac Church as early as the 4th century, are possible sources for the *muwashshah*. For example, the composer Nûrî Iskandar has called attention to the similarity between the modes and rhythms of the *muwashshahât* and Syriac liturgical songs, suggesting Syriac and/or Byzantine influences (personal communication, 1997). Be that as it may, the *muwashshah* should be understood as a musical-poetic genre of probable Andalusian provenance but of mixed melodic, rhythmic, and literary heritage. It might also be wise to differentiate between the *muwashshahât* as poetic texts, composed and sung in al-Andalus, and the *muwashshah* as a poetic-musical genre that has multiple sources but which assumed different forms wherever it was composed and performed. Indeed, often the same poetic texts are set to entirely different melodies in Syria and Morocco, though both are termed *muwashshahât andalusiyya*.⁴

The Structure of the *Muwashshahât*

As for the structure of the *muwashshahât*, the *muwashshah* is a "strophic" poetic form, that is, composed of verses of metrical poetry set to music (al-Hilû 1965; Liu and Monroe 1989). However, it is important to note that the *muwashshah* usually does not closely follow the classical Arabic rules of poetic meter, such as the system of 'arûd and buhûr established by the eighth century grammarian al-Khalîl Ibn Ahmad al-Farâhîdî. Rather, the *îqâ'* or meter of a *muwashshah* usually departs from the poetic meter. In fact, some *muwashshahât* performed in Syria utilize more than one meter for the different sections of the song (see below). Literary scholars base their conclusions about the poetic meter of a *muwashshah* on the assumption that the *muwashshahât* are poems, when in fact they were always meant to be sung and in most cases depart from the poetic meter. The lyrics are made to fit the musical rhythm through

⁴ Although most Moroccan scholars refer to the *muwashshahât* as Andalusian, many are beginning to use the earlier term *al-âla* (or *al-âla al-maghribiyya*), which means "Moroccan instrumental music" (al-Shâmî 1984). For more on the *muwashshah* in North Africa, see Guettat 2000.

the use of filler words such as "yâ layl" (O Night), and nonsense syllables such as "yâ lâ lâli," and other words derived from Arabic, Turkish, and Persian. This is especially the case in Aleppo, where not only are there heavy Ottoman influences on the music and culture but the various and complex rhythmic cycles that the Aleppine composers prefer require extensive use of filler words; they become an aspect of the song's aesthetics.

Terminology

There are a number of different terms that are used to describe the structure of the *muwashshah*, and different terms are used in different countries, confusing the matter. For the sake of clarity I follow the terminology commonly used in Aleppo, which is used to an extent as well in Egypt, while indicating the equivalents in Egyptian and Andalusian terminology.

1) *dawr*

The first verse of a *muwashshah* is termed the *dawr* (pl. *adwân*), which means "round" or "turn" (as does the vocal genre of the same name). The *dawr* consists of a line (*bayt*, pl. *abyât*) of poetry, sometimes two, each having the same meter and rhyme scheme. The *dawr* is sometimes referred to as the *badaniyya* ("body") and corresponds in the Andalusian *muwashshah* to what was called the *matla'* or *madhhab*, the "opening" verse.

2) *khâna*

The *khâna* (pl. *khânât*), which means "inn" or "house," is the second verse of a *muwashshah*. This is sometimes called the *silsila* ("chain") and corresponds to the verse that follows the *matla'* or opening line in the Andalusian *muwashshah*. The *khâna* is generally composed to a different melody (*lahn*) from the melody of the *dawr*, and it may have a different rhyme and sometimes a different meter.

3) *ghitâ'*

Finally, the *muwashshah* ends with the *ghitâ'* ("cover") or *qafila* ("lock," or "closing"), the final verse or which corresponds to the *kharja* ("exit") or *qafila* of the Andalusian *muwashshah*. The *ghitâ'* follows the same melody and rhythm as the *dawr* and has the same rhyme and meter.

Varieties of *Muwashshahât*

There are numerous varieties of Andalusian *muwashshahât*, according to the number and arrangement of the verses and the rhythms used. In terms of the arrangement of the lyrics, there are two general types: *tâmm* ("complete") and *aqra'* ("bald"). If a *muwashshah* begins with the *matla'* or opening verse of the original poem, it is called *tâmm* or "complete." In musical terms, if the song begins and ends with the same verse, it is *tâmm*. An example is the well-known *muwashshah* *Yâ bahjat al-rûh*, composed by the Egyptian composer Sayyid Darwîsh in the *maqâm hijâz kâr kurd*. However, if a *muwashshah* begins with the verses of the poem and then the opening refrain, it is called *aqra'*, or "bald." A well-known example of an *aqra'* type of *muwashshah* is *Yâ man la'ibat bihi shamûlu* by an anonymous composer in the *maqâm rast*. The "bald" variety is the most common in Aleppo today; that is, most of the *muwashshahât* begin with the main verses of the original poem upon which they are based, followed by the refrain. It should be noted that many musical *muwashshahât* take their lyrics from different or overlapping sections of the same poem.

The Three Basic Melodic Patterns of Syrian *Muwashshahât*

The majority of the *muwashshahât* performed in Syria today tend to follow one of three melodic patterns:

1) AABA: *dawr* (2X) - *khâna* - *ghitâ'*

This pattern follows a modified sonata form, or AABA, the A section being the *dawr* and *ghitâ'*, and the B section being the *khâna*. Individual *muwashshahât* of this pattern assume many variations but their essential structure remains the same: i.e., a return to the melody of the *dawr* at the *ghitâ'*, the end of the song., with the *khâna* following a distinct melody often featuring modulation to a different but related *maqâm*. In some ways this structure is similar to that of the standard jazz tune consisting of a "head" followed by a "bridge" and then a return to the "head" (also known as AABA structure), and in fact many of my musical interlocutors in Syria noted the structural similarities between the *muwashshah* and standard jazz tune.

Two well-known examples of *muwashshahât* that follow the AABA pattern are *Sihtu wajdan* (composed by Sayyid Darwîsh in *maqâm sâz kâr*), and *Yâ 'uyûnan râmiyyât* (composed by 'Umar al-Batsh in *maqâm hijâz kâr*).

2) AAAA: *dawr-dawr...*

In this pattern the main melody is repeated over and over, each time with different verses, and each termed a *dawr* (hence there is no *khâna* or *ghitâ*). This form is common among *muwashshahât* by anonymous older composers (often listed in collections simply as *qadîm*, though precisely how old they are is uncertain; few are actually thought to predate the Ottoman period in Syria given the heavy Ottoman influences heard in their melodies). 'Umar al-Batsh composed *khânât* for some *muwashshahât* of this pattern, such as the well-known *Yâ 'udhayb al-marshaf* (*maqâm sûznâk*), among others.

Two well-known examples of *muwashshahât* that follow the AAAA pattern are *Yâ shâdî al-alhân* (composed by Sayyid Darwîsh in *maqâm sâz kâr*), and *Law kunta tadri ma al-hubbu yaf'al* (composed by Majdî al-'Aqlî in *maqâm huzâm*).

3) ABAB: *dawr-khâna-dawr-khâna*

Finally, the third pattern corresponds to a modified rondo form, with alternations of A and B sections with a return to a refrain at the end. Two well-known examples of *muwashshahât* that follow the ABAB pattern are *Yâ man la'ibat* (*qadîm*, in *maqâm râst*), and *bil-ladhi askar* (*qadîm*, in *maqâm bayyâtî*). This pattern tends to have simpler *îqâ'ât*, and modal modulations are rare.

There are of course other varieties of *muwashshahât* and not all can easily be classified according to these three categories, though most of the *muwashshahât* that are performed in Aleppo today follow one of these three patterns. Some have elaborate *khânât* that provide the vocalist considerable freedom; others have *silsila* sections interpolated in the *khâna*, and so forth. The great Aleppine composer 'Ali al-Darwish, in his unpublished manuscript *al-Darr al-haqîqî fî alhân al-mûsîqâ*, categorized the *muwashshahât* into eight different varieties, according to their meters, including the *qadd halabî* genre (al-Darwish n.d.; see also al-Sharîf 1991).

Themes of the *Muwashshah*

The *muwashshahât* treat a variety of themes common to Arabic poetry in general. These include a number of general themes (see Rahîm 1987). Perhaps the most prominent theme of the *muwashshahât* is love (*ghazal*): a large number of the lyrics constitute complaints about the cruelty of the beloved, the pain of separation, and longing for the reunion with the beloved after a period of separation. Praising or addressing the

beloved's eyes and addressing the beloved as a gazelle are common themes, as in the popular *Yâ fâtin al-ghuzlân* [O enchanter of gazelles], *qadîm*, in *maqâm hijâz*, whose lyrics begin with the following verses:

yâ fâtin al-ghuzlân ismah wa kallimnî
yakfî kalâm an-nâs wa'nta mukhâsimnî
al-laylu 'alayya tâl w'ad-dam'u sal silsâl
w'al-qalb lak mayâl hubbak mujannanî
 [O enchanter of gazelles, have mercy and speak to me
 Gossip is enough to make you my enemy
 The night has lengthened and my tears flow like a fountain
 My heart yearns for you, your love drives me mad]⁵

Another common theme of the *muwashshahât* is praise (*madîh*), which can include praise of the Prophet (especially in religious *muwashshahât*), patrons (such as the *khalîfa*), and friends. Examples include *Yâ imâm al-rusul*, *Yâ rasul allâh*, and Sabri Moudallal's *Yâ rahmân yâ basîr*, among others.

Muwashshahât that feature satire (*hijâ'*) are rare today, though often satirical intentions are revealed in a performance context, for example when vocalists will sing songs with lyrics that mention the name of a patron or audience member in a satirical fashion. An attempt to reconcile two well known Aleppine vocalists ended when a commonly performed *muwashshah* that includes the first name of one of the singers was used by the other to poke fun at him.

Also common are *muwashshahât* that treat the theme of wine (known poetically as *khamriyyât*). Lyrics that mention the filling of cups, drunkenness, and the effects of wine are legion (see Kennedy 1997). Many of the above themes, including or even especially the wine song, can also be read as having an undercurrent of Sufi meaning. Many commentators have acknowledged the close link between Arab music and the Sufi practices of *samâ'* (al-'Aqîlî 1979, Liu and Monroe 1989, Rahîm 1987, among others). Most lyrics of *muwashshahât* offer several levels of potential meaning, including spiritual readings of *ghazal*, *madîh*, and *khamariyyât* songs.

Indeed, there is often no clear distinction between sacred and secular *muwashshahât* (see Shannon 2003b). Some *muwashshahât* are

⁵ This loose and awkward translation, my own, does not capture the magic of the Arabic lyrics. For a recording of this song, see Al-Turath Ensemble 1997.

performed in both secular and sacred contexts, whereas others are decidedly spiritual, including most whose theme is *madīh*, such as *Yâ rasûl allâh*. Religious *muwashshahât* such as *Yâ rasûl allâh* are performed in the *dhikr*, *mawlid*-s, and other religious occasions. *Dhikr* is held daily in Aleppo and there are numerous *munshidûn* (vocalists who specialize in religious repertoires, from the word *inshâd*) in the city who perform regularly, the more famous being Sabrî Moudallal and Hassan Haffâr. Younger singers also sing in both secular and sacred contexts.

al-Qudûd al-Halabiyya: Origins and Characteristics

The *qadd halabi* or "Aleppine" *qadd* genre is among the most popular in contemporary Syria. Although its precise origins are a matter of debate, because of Aleppo's role as a meeting place and collecting place of different traditions, many songs were attributed to Aleppo that are from other cities and countries, especially Homs, and Turkey, Iraq, Egypt, Persia.

The word *qadd* in Arabic means "equivalent," as in: *hadha 'ala qadd dhak*, meaning "this is 'equivalent to' or 'appropriate for' that." In the *qadd*, religious lyrics are set to the melodies of popular folk songs. The reverse it also the case, taking a religious song and replacing the lyrics with more profane lyrics. Such musical contrafaction is a common principle in many musical traditions; other examples in Arab music include Muhammad 'Abd al-Wahhâb's and the Rahbânî Brothers' "borrowing" of themes from European music (Fairuz in effect sings many Mozart *qudûd*).

The *qudûd*-proper are generally in *al-fusha*, the classical or modern standard variety of Arabic, and not colloquial Arabic, though in general today any of the light songs presented at the end of the *wasla* are termed *qudûd* even if they are not technically *qudûd*: for example, *Faug al-nakhl*, which is Iraqi; *Yâ jamîlû*, which is probably of Kurdish origin, *Sibûnî yâ nâss*, which may be Egyptian (though there is an old Homsî song that is very similar), and other colloquial songs that are commonly labeled "*qudûd*."

Structure and Function in the *Wasla*

Structurally the *qudûd* are similar to the *muwashshahât*, following the AABA or ABAB structure, but usually much simpler, having a simple rhythm, commonly 4/4, 2/4, rarely 6/8. 'Alî al-Darwîsh, Nadîm al-Darwîsh, and others have suggested that the *qudûd* are in fact second-rate *muwashshahât* (the eighth variety in 'Alî al-Darwîsh's classification), somehow watered down or simplified for popular consumption. Their

function is to lighten the atmosphere of the *wasla*. *Qudûd* tend to be performed at the conclusion of a *wasla*, when everyone gets up and dances and has a good time, *mkayifin*. The structure of the *wasla* is, as I suggest above, very similar to and perhaps even modeled on that of the *dhikr* and the *fasil*, which also begin with slow and heavy rhythms and end in quick, often ecstatic rhythms and dancing, creating a sense of release.

Examples of popular *qudûd* and their classical counterparts in *maqâm al-hijâz* are:

1. *al-Bulbul naghâ 'ala ghusn al-full* = *Yâ layl azharat al-hasnâ'*
2. *li-Arsul salâmî la-sâlim* = *li-Arsul salâmî la-sayyidî* = *Khalid bin al-walîd*
3. *Bishrû ahl al-ma'âlî* = *Kunta fayn yâ hilû*
4. *Min sahar tilka al-'uyûn* = *Yâ mayla 'alâ al-ghusûn*

Other common *qudûd* include:

1. *Yâ al-asmar al-laww (hijaz)*, about a dark-skinned beloved
2. *al-Qarasiyya (bayyati)*, about sour prune grown in Aleppo and eaten by the "Effendiyya" class (*akal al-afandiyya*).

The *Muwashshah* and *Qudûd* in Modern Syria

The *muwashshahât* arrived in the Levant as early as the 12th century (al-Afandî 1999). Itinerant scholars and pilgrims brought the poetic and musical form to the Levant; indeed some argue that the Sufi master Muhî al-Dîn Ibn al-'Arabî (1165-1240), who composed religious *muwashshahât*, may have introduced the *muwashshahât* to the Levant (Rahîm 1987). Damascus, though once the center of the Umayyad Dynasty, was less important than other cities in the Levant as a musical center, mostly because during the Ottoman empire it was a secondary city, as well as a highly conservative religious center where music was considered suspicious. Yet, Damascene artists made important contributions to the art of the *muwashshah*, including the great Ahmad Abû Khalfî al-Qabbânî (1841-1902), who composed numerous *muwashshahât* as well as lighter songs and *qudûd*. al-Qabbânî (the great uncle of the poet Nizâr Qabbânî) was a student of al-Shaykh Ahmad 'Aqîl of Aleppo. He worked in the theater in Damascus but left because of its conservative atmosphere. He helped to found the musical theater in Cairo and traveled as far as Chicago to the Columbian World Exposition of 1893, where he presented such works as the now classic *Yâ mâl al-shâm* [O the wealth of Damascus]. Among the important Damascene artists from the 20th C who composed and performed *muwashshahât* Muhammad Muhsin (1922 -) stands out as an innovative composer who introduced a greater role for

the soloist than had been previously practiced (al-Sharîf 1991). In such works as *Yâ ghazâlâ*, sung by the vocalist Hanân in the early 1950s, the soloist alternates with the chorus on the *dawr*, and sings solo on the *khâna*. Both the chorus and the soloist sing the *ghita'*. Halîm al-Rûmî also followed this style, sort of a mix between the Egyptian and Aleppine styles of performance. Muhsin also shortened the conventional *yâ layl* and *aman* sections. Other important Damascene artists include Sa'id Farhât, Zuhayr and 'Adnân Manînî, 'Abd al-Fattâh Sukkar, 'Adnân Abû al-Shâmât, Khadr Junayd, and performers of religious *muwashshahât* such as Hamza Shâkur and his teacher Tawfiq al-Munajjad (d. 1999).

Aleppo and Homs were the two major centers of Arabic song in the Levant in the 18th and 19th centuries, as was Aleppo, sometimes considered to be the capital of Arab music at the time. Though less known than Aleppo, Homs, with its beautiful gardens situated along the banks of the rivers al-'Âsi (Orontes) and Mimâs, was host to some of the foremost composers and singers of *muwashshahât* and *qudûd*. Among these was the great poet Amîn al-Jundî (1766-1841), who both composed and compiled an anthology of *muwashshahât* and *qudûd*, arranged according to their melodies and lyrics (Qala'hjî 1988). al-Jundi played a critical role in the composition and transmission of *muwashshahât* and *qudûd*, which he learned during stays in Aleppo, Egypt, and elsewhere. Recent scholarship has brought to light that many of the *muwashshahât* sung today in Aleppo were composed by al-Jundi though people have forgotten him, attributing the words and melody to "*qadîm*" (old) or "*majhûl*," anonymous (see Qala'hjî 1988). Today, Homs, though eclipsed by Aleppo and Damascus, still has a vibrant community of fine performers and listeners who enjoy regular *sahrât* and nights of *tarab*.

Aleppo

From the 18th through the early 20th Centuries, Aleppo (*al-Shahbâ'*, the Luminous) was the capital of Arab music. Known as *Umm al-tarab* (The Mother of *tarab*, referring to the special emotional state that the older songs evoke in listeners. See Racy 2003; Shannon 2003), Aleppo was an important commercial, religious, and artistic center from the Middle Ages until late 19th C. (Marcus 1989). Because of its commercial and religious importance, Aleppo was a vibrant town that collected the folklore and musical traditions of the numerous peoples who came through her on their travels along the Silk Road. Therefore we find in Aleppine music a mixture of styles: Arabic, Turkish, Persian, Kurdish, Balkan, European, and others (see Shannon 2001).

Aleppo has for centuries been a bastion of religious song. After the Turkish city of Konya, Aleppo is the second major center of the Mawlawiyya Sufi sect established by Jalâl al-Dîn Rûmî in the 13th century. Among the past master religious singers of Aleppo – the so-called *mashâyikh halab* – include such figures as Ahmad 'Aqîl, Sâlih al-Jadhba, Muhammad Junayd, Ahmad al-Faqsh, and other old-timers who specialized in *muwashshahât*, *qasâ'id*, and other varieties of religious song (Mahannâ 1998; al-Sharîf 1991). Even today, most of Aleppo's best singers and musicians have had strong religious training, especially in the various Islamic rituals such as *dhikr*, the call to prayer (*adhân*), in addition to recitation of the Qur'ân (*tajwîd*). Ironically, given debates about the legitimacy of music in Islam, the mosque is a de facto conservatory of Arab music in Aleppo – an institution for the preservation of the major genres of Arab song and training in performance practice. The great Egyptian composer Dawûd Husnî (who was Jewish) once remarked, "So long as there is recitation of the Qur'ân there will be Arab music" (Danielson 1997). In Aleppo they say that so long as there are young people attending the *dhikr*, there is no need to fear for the future of Arabic song. Training in the different Christian liturgies of Aleppo has also been the spring-board for a number of contemporary Arab musicians and singers (Syrian Jews were also prominent instrumentalists and instrument makers until the middle of the 20th century).

The *Muwashshahât* in Aleppo

Like 19th century Egyptian performance practice, in Aleppo there is more emphasis on solo singer, often alternating with the chorus on the *dawr* and soloing in the *khâna*, and more extended *layâlî* sections, sometimes featuring each member of the chorus. The *muwashshahât* in Aleppo utilize of wider range of *maqâmât* and tempos than used elsewhere, especially the longer and more complex ones such as *al-shanbar al-halabî* (24/4) and different varieties of *aqşâq* or syncopated rhythms. Moreover, in Aleppo, unlike Cairo or other cities where the *muwashshahât* were traditionally performed, the *muwashshahât* are accompanied by a specific dance style known as *Raqs al-samâh*. Sâlih al-Jadhba and 'Umar al-Batsh were among the chief propagators of this dance, which is slow and regal, like the rhythms of the *muwashshahât* (see Bin Dhurayl 1989).

Major Aleppine Composers and Singers of *Muwashshahât*

Among the more prominent composers and performers of *muwashshahât* in Aleppo is the great Aleppine master teacher and musician 'Alî al-Darwîsh (1884-1952). Though most famous as a teacher (Muhammad 'Abd al-Wahhâb and Riyyâd al-Sinbâtî were among his students in Cairo) and as a collector and transcriber of *muwashshahât*, Shaykh 'Alî, as he is known in Aleppo, also composed *muwashshahât*.

It is 'Alî al-Darwîsh's contemporary, the great 'Umar al-Batsh (1885-1950), who is remembered as Aleppo's foremost *wishshâh*. al-Batsh composed over 140 *muwashshahât*, many of which survive today because al-Batsh notated them (stories say that he learned to write music when he played trumpet and trombone while serving in the Ottoman army). Twenty of his *muwashshahât* are found in the collection *Min kunûzinâ*, and they are all beautiful.

al-Batsh was known for his compositional skills and his great memory, and Aleppines like to tell the story of the visit of Muhammad 'Abd al-Wahhâb to Aleppo in 1932 and his meeting with 'Umar al-Batsh. 'Abd al-Wahhâb met with al-Batsh and a group of prominent Aleppine artists and *sammî'a* (skilled listeners) and asked them if they had any *muwashshahât* composed in *maqâm al-yakâh* – a rare mode for the composition of *muwashshahât*. al-Batsh responded that they indeed had a complete *wasla* in that *maqâm*, but when 'Abd al-Wahhâb asked if he could hear them, al-Batsh replied that the time of day was inappropriate for performing that mode, it being evening and, according to medieval theories, the morning was the better time for performing *maqâm al-yakâh*. He therefore asked the young Egyptian star to come back the following morning. After 'Abd al-Wahhâb had left, so the story goes, another composer turned to al-Batsh and cried, "You know we don't have any *muwashshahât* in that *maqâm*! What are you going to do?!" and al-Batsh replied, "wa lâ himmak, Don't you worry" and proceeded in the course of that evening to compose five *muwashshahât* in *maqâm al-yakâh* and rehearse a small chorus so that when 'Abd al-Wahhâb returned the next morning he heard a complete *wasla* in *maqâm al-yakâh*!

Among the great living singers who follow the old school is Sabrî Moudallal (b. 1918), the ever youthful nonagenarian who still occasionally performs. Moudallal was a student of 'Umar al-Batsh in the 1930s and 1940s. In addition to performing the classical repertory, Moudallal has composed over 40 *muwashshahât*, both of *madîh* and *ghazal* varieties. His religious background has been a strong influence on his performance style; until the late 1990s Sabrî Moudallal still gave the noon call to prayer

at Aleppo's Great Mosque and is a *munshid* at many *dhikr*-s, *mawlid*-s and weddings in the city.

Other performers and composers of the *muwashshah* in Aleppo or who performed in Aleppo even if they weren't of Aleppine origin, include the following (al-Sharif 1991):

Bakrî al-Kurdî	Ibrahîm Jawdat	<u>Younger Vocalists:</u>
Bahjat Hasân	Muhammad Qadrî	'Umar Sarmînî
Fu'âd al-Khantumânî	Dalâl	Mahmoud Fâris
Muhammad al-Bassâl		Rabî al-Shahîr
'Abd al-Qâdir Hajjâr	<u>Women Vocalists:</u>	Muhammad
Nadîm al-Darwîsh	Mary Jubrân	Hamâdiyya
Muhammad Khairî	Zakiyya Hamdân	'Abûd Bashîr
Majdî al-'Aqlî	Mahâ al-Jâbirî	'Umar Sâbûnî
Mustafa Hilâl	Sahar	Humâm Khairî
Sabâh Fakhri	Karawân	Nihâd Najjâr
Hassan al-Haffâr	Nûr al-Hudâ	

Conclusions

The *muwashshahât* are among the most beautiful of Arabic songs, combining poetic richness with musical and vocal splendor, or *rawnaq*. Though in decline in the Arab World today, they remain important teaching tools, and anyone who hopes to master the *maqâmât* and *îqâ'ât* would be well advised to study the *muwashshahât* intensively. Even as far back as al-Fârâbî, the memorization of songs was considered the first stage in musical development, the ability to improvise and the ability to discuss rationally what you play are the 2nd and 3rd stages, respectively (al-Fârâbî 1967; Muhammad Qadrî Dalâl, personal communication 1997).

Both the *muwashshahât* and the *qudûd* are important components of the contemporary musical scene in Syria and must be understood in relation to one another as "book ends," as it were, of the *wasla*, which is the major context for the performance of *muwashshahât* and *qudûd*. The *wasla* itself should be understood, I suggest, in the context of the Muslim *dhikr*: they share a similar structure and much of the same repertory. The performance of *muwashshahât* and *qudûd* in Syria is part of an established and vital tradition that emphasizes the values of heritage and authenticity and which places special emphasis on the older genres, especially in Aleppo. In the context of a veritable deluge of cheap pop songs from Egypt, Lebanon, and elsewhere (Syria too), the *muwashshahât* are often seen as a sort of last defense of tradition. This

concern with tradition and heritage has not blinded (most) Syrian musicians to the importance of finding new ways of expression, new genres and new styles that are appropriate to modern times. But this perennial need does not cancel out the equally vital need to preserve and understand that which has gone before. It seems to me, unfortunately, that too few young Arab musicians today are following that path and instead are jumping on the bandwagon of so-called modernization without having much if any grounding in the classical works.

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Selected Discography

What follows is a brief and certainly not exhaustive annotated discography of recordings by Syrian artists of *muwashshahât* and *qudûd*. I list primarily CD recordings that are available in North America but also

include information on commonly found (and usually unauthorized) cassette recordings, some of which circulate publicly.

Ensemble Al-Kindi

Ensemble Al-Kindi (1999). *Les Derviches Tourneurs de Damas/The Whirling Dervishes of Damascus*. Le Chant du Monde. 2 CD. CML 5741123.24

_____ (1998). *Syrie/Syria: Le Salon de Musique d'Alep/The Aleppian Music Room*. Le Chant du Monde. 2 CD. CML 5741108.09

Led by the indefatigable Julien "Jalaleddine" Weiss, this ensemble has recorded a wide array of Syria's diverse urban musical repertoires, both sacred and profane. These high quality recordings reflect the participating artists' long-standing experience performing with some of the best artists in Syria and the Arab world. 'Umar Sarmini, a protégé of Sabrî Moudallal, shines in both the *Crusades* and *Salon* recordings.

Sabâh Fakhri

Numerous recordings exist of the legendary Syrian vocalist, though they vary in quality depending on the source recordings. Many CDs and cassettes are bootleg and of suspect quality, though some are quite good. Recent recordings available on CD include:

Fakhri, Sabah, and Wadi al-Safi et al. *Two Tenors & Qantara: Historic Live Recording of Arabic Masters*. CD Ark21/Mondo Melodia 1868500142, 2000.

Beit Eddine Festival, Vols. 1 and 2 CBA113/114, n.d.

Mouwashahat. LPD510, n.d.

Sabâh Fakhri. LPD501, n.d.

Notable performances on cassette and CD (bootleg) include:

Venezuela Concert. 1987

Nagham al-Ams collection, produced by Dimashq lil-Sinema (now defunct) in the 1980s. This anthology features Fakhri singing complete *waslât* in the major *maqâmât*.

Sabrî Moudallal

Moudallal, Sabrî (1994). *Chants sacrés et profanes de Syrie*. CD. Blue Silver 303.

____ (1988). *Wasla d'Alep: Chants Traditionels de Syria*. CD. INÉDIT W 260007.

These are among the best recordings available of the traditional Aleppine *wasla*. The now nonagenarian Moudallal – semi-retired – has a distinctive voice, adhering to vocal styles from the 1930s and 40s, that one seldom hears today.

Al-Turath Ensemble

al-Turath Ensemble (1997). *La Música de al-Andalus. La Muwassaha/The Music in Spanish al-Andalus: The Muwashshah*. Junta de Andalucía/Consejería de Cultura. CD. Almagora DS-0123.

This recording, undertaken by the Spanish Andalusian regional cultural council, records a complete *wasla* in *maqâm hijâz* performed by members of the al-Turath ensemble in Aleppo. It is distinctive for featuring choral arrangements of *muwashshahât* with occasional solos, whereas Fakhri and others tend to feature the solo vocalist with occasional choral accompaniment.

Of course, in Syria there are hundreds of cassettes that feature various artists singing *muwashshahât* and *qudûd*, including Sabâh Fakhri, Muhammad Khairî, Bakrî al-Kurdî, Sabrî Moudallal, Umar Sarmîni, and a host of artists both well-known and otherwise. Specialty shops and cassette stands in Aleppo and Damascus cater to aficionados of “classical” Arab music (for example, I brought back from the field over 350 cassettes of a wide variety of music, some very rare, some banal).